CINEMA

Scripting a Screen Epic

Noted Tamil author **B. Jeyamohan** talks about the challenges in adapting an epic literary work like *Ponniyin Selvan* into a film

"Short story lends itself to cinema. It's difficult to adapt the novel into film and this is true the world over," says B. Jeyamohan, the celebrated Tamil author, literary critic and screenplay writer who stands on the cusp of wider fame today with several of his works being translated into English and film adaptations achieving popular success. His short story collection *Aram* (2011), translated by Priyamvada as *Stories of the True*, was published in 2022, and his 2003 novel *Ezham Ulagam*, translated by Suchitra Ramachandran as *The Abyss,* came out last month. Jeyamohan has been writing films for over two decades now, working with filmmakers like Shankar, Mani Ratnam and Bala. Vetrimaaran's *Viduthalai Part 1* (2023), inspired by Jeyamohan's short story 'Thunaivan', released in March. There is another horse in the race—the adaptation of Kalki R. Krishnamurthy's book *Ponniyin Selvan* (1954), for which Jeyamohan worked with Ratnam and Elango Kumaravel. The second part of the film released in April, after the first became a monster hit last year.

An epic like *Ponniyin Selvan* presents a unique task. "We can't condense, we need all the major characters and moments," says Jeyamohan. However, one of the main critiques for the film was the way characters meet despite the screenplay circumventing Kalki's overwritten portions and avoiding contrivances. Jeyamohan says that's part of Kalki's style: "Kalki was influenced by Dumas and George W.M. Reynolds." There are three things that need refinement when writing a screenplay for the modern audience, says Jeyamohan. "During Kalki's time, realism had not evolved as a school of aesthetics. People met and events occurred as coincidence." Second, he says, there was a lot of eavesdropping in such fiction. It wasn't true to life but characters overheard each other all the time. This can't happen in a film made today. "Third, emotions were conveyed through dramatic monologues. But we kept a few, like Aditha Karikalan's lament about Nandini." The makers had to invent scenarios where the inner traits of characters could translate visually. Says Jeyamohan, "There's no war in the book, only talks about war. But we need scenes of war to show Karikalan's anger and warrior nature that the book sings paeans about."

Even though the films take the liberty to let viewers connect some dots, Jeyamohan believes the share of people who have read the book is still quite small. "A film can't be made just for them. We have youth who watch movies from around the world....adults who have a healthy curiosity towards Tamil history. We can't make a *Baahubali* for them, Arunmozhivarman can't hit 10 enemy soldiers in a single whiplash. That'd be comical. Then there are readers who need the essence of the novel and the characters."

Recent adaptations of Tamil literature as larger-than-life popular films

Jeyamohan says there is a difference between **a film creator and a maker**—while one invites discourse, the other does an assembly-line production of cinema

